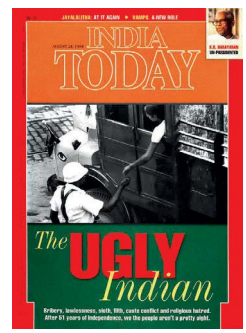
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

GDB GROSS DOMESTIC BEHAVIOUR

There is much talk in India about becoming the third largest economy in the world in terms of GDP (Gross Domestic Product) by 2030. This is a valid ambition that India must work aggressively towards achieving. Besides that, other factors determine whether a nation is regarded as a developed country: high human development indices straddling health and education, and world-class infrastructure that facilitates both ease of living and business. Yet there's another layer of reality that these criteria do not capture. This week, we propose an additional method beyond GDP to gauge a country's progress on the development path. We are calling it Gross Domestic Behaviour (GDB). Think of it as the 'software' layer of society that interacts symbiotically with hard material factors: an umbilical cord ties GDP with GDB.

These are aspects difficult to quantify but easy to experience. The contrasts are stark. The well-ordered cityscapes of the developed world clearly rest on an external grid of excellent infrastructure that maximises life chances for all, guaranteeing the efficiency of a productive society. But they also flow from an invisible infrastructure of inner discipline. Their public spaces are kept clean not just by machines, but by an ingrained culture of empathy in which everyone participates. Their disciplined lane driving originates in the mind. The absence of this 'civic faculty' in India is so settled a fact that it's often taken to be in our nature. We felt the idea of development could be enriched with such invisible markers that have tangible economic effects. Take safety in public spaces. Or broad-mindedness about gender, ethnicity, caste, religion, or language. It's clear to see that these underpin livelihoods, enabling broad, unfettered economic participation. Stopping callous littering or ensuring women's safety carries direct benefits: it will provide better health for our citizens and attract more foreign tourists.



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So, we thought of creating a barometer to quantify aspects of Indian reality that we anecdotally witness. There is a well-known management mantra: if you want to change anything, measure it first. This week's cover story is an attempt to do that. We present the first India Today GDB (Gross Domestic Behaviour) Survey, done in collaboration with data analytics firm How India Lives. Conducted across 21 states and one Union territory with 9,188 respondents, we sought to gauge attitudes across four dimensions: Civic Behaviour, Public Safety, Gender Attitudes and Diversity & Discrimination. The results are always revelatory. In some cases, there is a tendency in such surveys to express the socially appropriate behaviour but do the opposite. For instance, according to the study, 85 per cent of Indians disapprove of ticketless travel. However, this struggles to hold up when cross-matched with data from the Indian Railways: 36 million ticketless or irregular travel cases were reported in 2023-24, yielding Rs 2,231.74 crore through fines. Then again, 88 per cent say they will report a serious accident if they spot one, but official figures tell us lack of timely medical attention causes 50 per cent of fatalities. This 'reporting diffidence' probably stems from lacking trust in the legal system. Despite these contradictions, we get fascinating insights into the differences in regional attitudes.

Nevertheless, there is depressing candour too: 61 per cent of Indians are willing to pay bribes; UP tops with 94 per cent. Similarly, 52 per cent are okay with cash transactions on property to avoid taxes. This collective surrender to corruption as a way of life is also a statement on the system. On gender, tradition holds firm: 67 per cent oppose women marrying against parental wishes, and 69 per cent think male members should have the final say in significant household matters. Interfaith and intercaste marriages elicit high veto rates of 61 per cent and 56 per cent, respectively. Only 54 per cent oppose housing societies prohibiting certain foods, though happily, 70 per cent welcome religious diversity in neighbourhoods. The high regional variation in attitudes confirms a global correlation between human development indices and the GDB, as revealed by the progressive response profile of Kerala and Tamil Nadu compared to northern states.

Four guest columnists interpret the data in illuminating ways. Sociologist Dipankar Gupta points out that "an overwhelming number of people know what correct civic behaviour is but don't follow what they know to be proper". In the gap between word and deed, he sees space for enforcement. Guwahati-based professor and gender activist Rakhee Kalita Moral is struck by "the near-concurrence between urban and rural India" on gender issues, including in the 8.5 per cent who "somewhat agree" on wife-beating being "valid punishment for disobedience". Social anthropologist Ravinder Kaur notes the "all-round conservatism" on diversity. Former UP Director General of Police Vikram Singh leaves us with a line that should become our motto as we welcome foreign tourist footfalls: "Safety is not just the absence of danger, but the presence of trust." The purpose of this is to hold a mirror to society, which is what the role of media is. No survey is perfect but, hopefully, this will provoke public discourse on our civic behaviour. Education is key: civic consciousness can and must be taught and learnt. Enforcement, too, is vital. If we are to become a Viksit Bharat by 2047, we must pay as much attention to GDB as we do to GDP.

(Aroon Purie)

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